

ARTIST STATEMENT

People display an attitude of superiority over the animals with whom we share our planet. However, humans are animals, and our actions are driven by instinct, just as with any other creature. The tendency to separate ourselves from other species has always intrigued me. My work draws comparisons between humans and other animals in order to emphasize the commonality between us and them.

I explore this concept from two angles. The first is through the subject matter of an art piece. My work focuses on physical similarities, such as expression, behavior, body language, and musculature, between humans and other primates. The second is through aesthetics and technique. I paint with an animalistic approach, using marks that contain the visceral vitality that has been taken away from people by society. This self-enforced restraint on freedom is what defines us most against other animals. By painting without restriction, I classify myself, the artist, as an animal, thus characterizing humans as members of an ape species rather than as members of a fabricated greater society.

Comedy and controversy also play important roles in my work. I anthropomorphize primates, leading to a humorous approach to more controversial subjects. Comedy has the power to reach people without inciting them to raise up their defenses; in seeing the familiarity, despite the ridiculousness, in my personified depictions of animals, it is hard to dismiss our likeness. Likewise, in using controversial themes in my work, I elevate the issue of animal equality to the forefront of subjects that are already being debated.

Through my work, I hope that the viewer will begin to contemplate the human role in the natural environment, as well as take away a greater respect for the creatures whose worlds we inhabit.